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From the editor-in-chief

We opened the INDIA TODAY Newsmaker of the Year series in 2001. Naturally, there was no debate then as to who earned that title: Osama bin Laden, the man behind 9/11. Between then and now our choice has usually centred around key political figures at the centre of events in the year, whether we agreed with their ideology or approved of their deeds. Last year, after eight major attacks culminated in the horror of 26/11, our choice for Newsmaker was the terrorist who held the country hostage for a year.

This year I have to say things have been very different, both in the news business and in our final choice of Newsmaker. Half of India's population may be under the age of 35, but our politicians at the helm of affairs tend to be geriatric. The world in contrast is getting younger leaders as is so aptly symbolised by the election of the 48-year-old Barack Obama as the American President. However, there is change in the air in India too. In the year 2009, after what was a very long time, a young Indian politician made the country sit up and pay attention.

That he owns a famous and powerful surname is no surprise. Sadly these days, dynasty is common across the entire political spectrum and at every level of the political ladder. What is significant about Rahul Gandhi's emergence in 2009 is not that he is a member of a family of three prime ministers. Why he catches the eye is that his entire approach to politics is very distinctly different from the Congress style of operations we have been used to for decades. Until 2009, Rahul was in the shadow of his mother as a politician and public figure. For the first time in the year, he seemed to find his own voice and his own style. Rahul has used his position in the Congress to defy its deeply-entrenched traditions.

The Congress's decision to contest without a coalition partner in some key states during the Lok Sabha elections was Rahul's idea. The party more than doubled its seats in Uttar Pradesh from nine to 21. Rahul has pushed the Congress's two flagship schemes—RTI and NREGA—into their strength in the electoral process. His way of functioning seems to fall somewhere between an NGO and a company.

Today Rahul makes news wherever he goes. It could be walking into someone's hut during his personal 'discovery of India' journeys or talking to the youth in Aligarh about engagement and empowerment. It must be said that he does not boast of a list of accomplishments and achievements. Gandhi Junior is more of a symbol, an idea that India yearns for. It is one of a transformation to an Indian politics centred around development rather than power. Whether that will happen or not is another question, but without doubt Rahul has made the year his own.

It must be remembered that Rahul Gandhi is at the beginning of his political career. To my mind, his greatest attribute is that he has not succumbed to the institutional sycophancy of the Congress. The job of prime minister is his for the asking. He has resisted that and that makes him different from the self-serving power hungry politicians who infest our politics. This is the fourth time he is on an INDIA TODAY cover and at 39, happens to be our youngest Newsmaker of the Year, quite fitting in this age of Obama. All that can be said is good luck, Mr Gandhi. India awaits you.

(Aron Purie)



OUR JANUARY
2009 COVER